

Cajun tempeh with roasted green beans and corn

This is a striking dish—colorful and packed with flavor. It makes great use of a dry rub that gives the tempeh a brilliant flavor and crisp texture. It's spicy, but not too hot. Interestingly, tempeh does not need any additional moisture (such as a marinade or an egg wash, for example) for the spice rub to adhere to it.

Tender asparagus in season works nicely as a substitute for the green beans. Try black Japonica or another mixed dark or red rice as an accompaniment to this dish. Top with a dollop of Simple Tofu Sour Cream.

1 cup fresh or frozen corn kernels [120g]

¼ pound fresh green beans, sliced in half if large [125g]

1 tablespoon olive oil

½ teaspoon dried thyme

½ teaspoon salt

Freshly ground pepper

1 package (8 ounces) tempeh [125g]

2½ tablespoons Cajun Spice Rub (recipe follows)

¼ cup vegetable oil [60ml]

1 large onion, thinly sliced

3 garlic cloves, minced

⅓ cup vegetable stock or water [75g]

Simple Tofu Sour Cream (recipe on page 148)

1. **Preheat** the oven to 425°F [220°C]. In a medium bowl, toss the corn and green beans with the olive oil to coat. Season with the thyme, salt, and a light grinding of pepper. Spread out on a baking sheet and roast for 20 to 25 minutes, tossing once or twice, until the corn is lightly browned around the edges and the beans are slightly wrinkled and a tad browned.

2. Meanwhile, **slice** the tempeh horizontally so it is half as thick, then cut it cross-wise in half so there are 4 squares. Rub both sides of the tempeh squares with enough of the spice rub to coat. Reserve any extra spice rub.
3. In a large cast-iron or nonstick skillet, **heat** the vegetable oil over medium-high heat. When very hot and just shimmering, add the tempeh squares and fry, turning once, until nicely browned—even a tad blackened—on both sides, 2 to 3 minutes. Remove from the pan and drain on paper towels. As soon as the tempeh is cool enough to handle, cut into 1-inch [2.5-cm] squares.
4. **Pour** off all but 1½ tablespoons of the oil from the skillet. Reduce the heat to medium, then add the onion and cook, stirring occasionally, until it is soft and deeply browned, 10 to 15 minutes. About 2 minutes before the onion is done, add the garlic and any reserved spice rub.
5. Add the tempeh and the roasted corn and green beans. Increase the heat to high, add the stock, and bring to a boil. **Stir** gently but constantly for a minute or so, scraping up any browned bits from the bottom of the pan with a wooden spoon, until the liquid reduces and creates a light sauce. Serve the tempeh and vegetables topped with Simple Tofu Sour Cream.

SERVES 2

Cajun spice rub

1½ tablespoons unrefined cane sugar

2 teaspoons imported sweet paprika

2 teaspoons powdered mustard

2 teaspoons cumin seeds

2 teaspoon dried oregano

2 teaspoons dried basil

1 teaspoon fennel seeds

1 teaspoon salt

1 teaspoon black peppercorns

¼ teaspoon cayenne pepper

In a spice grinder, **whiz** all the rub ingredients to a fine powder. Transfer to a covered jar and store at cool room temperature for up to 1 month.

MAKES ABOUT ⅓ CUP [75ML]